

How to...

Share one computer among multiple users

Solutions that share a PC between multiple users help SOHOs utilise their PCs to maximise productivity as well as cut IT-infrastructure costs. Call centres, hospitals, educational centres, etc also find it useful. You may employ it to share your home PC with your children.

We used one such solution—+ONE PC—that uses the time-slicing technique to share a PC. Its pack contains a PCI display card, a connector box, a software CD, a 15 feet long SVGA cable and a USB extension cable.

+ONE PC provides a computer with three extra I/O connections—keyboard, mouse and monitor—that use the resources of the host PC. Users can do light tasks such as surfing, playing small games and such. The host can instantly see changes made to its disk by the workstation.

Up to five users can share one PC using this solution. Their speed depends upon the configuration of the host PC.

System requirements

The host PC should have approximately 128 MB of RAM per user. This means that you need to have at least 256MB of RAM installed if you want to share the PC among two users. The OS should be either Windows 2000 or XP. The host PC



+ONE PC set up for two users

requires at least a Pentium III 500 MHz processor. Enhancing the system configuration of the host PC improves the performance of the workstations.

Installation

Shut down and switch off the host PC. Open the cabinet and install the bundled PCI display card. Connect one end of the SVGA extension cable to this card, and the second monitor to the other. Connect the second set of PS/2 keyboard and mouse to the bundled junction box. The box, in turn connects to the USB port of the host PC.

Next, power on the PC and press [Del] to enter the BIOS. Select the 'Integrated Peripherals' or 'BIOS features Setup'

menu, locate the 'Init Display First' or 'VGA- Boot-From' option., set it to 'AGP' or 'AGP/onboard', press [F10] to save your changes, and then restart the computer. The PC detects the new display card as ATI 128 Rage series and installs it automatically. Disable Power Management since +ONE PC doesn't support it. To do so, right-click on the desktop, select Properties, switch to the Screen Saver tab and click the 'Power...' button. Set all the fields in the selected power scheme settings to 'Never'.

Next, run the Setup file from the bundled software CD according to the type of processor that you have installed - with or without Hyper-threading - and install the necessary software. Select password protection and network administrative control options as and when they appear during the setup. Click OK to restart the PC when setup is finished. That's it, you're through!

Configuration

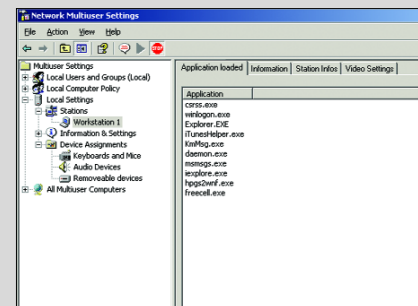
If the first boot brings up the logon screen on the workstation monitor too, then the workstation is configured properly. Initially, you may face some keyboard problems—both keyboards may work for the workstation only. However, the solution to this is simple: double-click the +ONE PC icon in the system tray and set the first keyboard for the Host PC. You will also see the Network Multiuser Settings window there. In its left panel, navigate to **Multiuser Settings > Local Settings > Device Assignments > Keyboard and Mice**. You will see two mice and keyboards configured in the right panel of the window; double-click 'Keyboard #01'.

In the properties window, go to the 'Keyboard Recognition via LED-Blinking' tab, and click on the 'Start LED-Blinking' button. This sets the lock LEDs blinking to help you identify the keyboard connected to Keyboard #01. You can also press a few keys to see the progress bar going up on the data received from the keyboard connected to the host PC. If the keyboard indeed is the right one, flip back to the General tab, select 'Station to Main Console,' and click OK. Now, you can use both the host and workstation PCs at the same time.

You can also use the Network Multiuser Settings window to monitor processes or applications. Go to **Multiuser Settings > Local Settings > Stations > Station 2**. Four tabs—Application loaded, Information, Station Infos and Video Settings—appear in the right panel. The first tab shows you

real-time information of all the running processes on the workstation. The Information tab displays general information about the workstation. The Station Infos tab lets you know the station name, which is changeable. It also shows up some configurations for the workstation, which you can define. The Video Settings tab helps you change the resolution and refresh rate of the workstation.

However, the system disappoints in the security department. The workstation user can delete or uninstall any software without as much as a warning being issued to the host. He can also shut down the host PC.



The Network Multiuser Settings lets you monitor processes and applications

In Sum

+ONE PC, along with the other solutions mentioned alongside, help you harness the spare power of a single PC to run multiple workstations. These are very cost-effective, especially in the scenarios we have mentioned. We've reviewed only +ONE PC here, but the others too do their job quite well. They are bound to bring about a tremendous reduction in your infrastructure bills.

Price Rs 6000 plus taxes (For 2 user set up)

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